The other asymmetry that India may soon have to confront is in respect of aircraft carriers. The Indian Navy is aiming for a three-carrier force (two on active duty, one in port for maintenance), though a clear timetable to achieve this goal has not been announced. Delivery of a second carrier has faced repeated delays and is expected to be ready only in 2022.[23] There have been indications that approval for a third carrier may not be forthcoming given the huge financial costs.[24] China on the other hand is accelerating efforts to have six carriers by 2035.[25] Overall, India will struggle to keep up with China's shipbuilding, which is the most ambitious in the world. Estimates are tricky for a variety of reasons, but India may have a total fleet strength (which goes beyond the surface and submarine combatants referred to earlier to include smaller vessels) of 175 vessels by 2027 while China could have as many as 425 vessels by 2030.[26]

These numbers suggest that China has overwhelming naval superiority. The Indian and Chinese navies could come into conflict when China is able to establish a larger presence in the Indian Ocean. However, once again, the numbers can be misleading. The Chinese navy must be distributed between several duties: offshore patrolling and deterrence (primarily of the US Navy); possible actions against Taiwan should it declare outright independence from the mainland; and defending China's claims in the East China Sea (against Japan) and the South China Sea (against various Southeast Asian countries). In addition, where the Himalaya have stopping power on land, distances and straits have stopping power at sea. Despite China's huge numbers of vessels, its navy will have to operate a long way from home base, which means long interior supply lines stretching back to eastern China and contending with narrow straits that can be closed in time of war.

China's supply problem may be eased by establishing a string of overseas bases in and around the Indian Ocean. The difficulty for its navy is that the bases would in turn be susceptible to Indian disruption, particularly if they are in East Africa, the Gulf of Aden, the Persian Gulf, or even coastal Pakistan. India's navy could intercept Chinese resupply missions from the mainland to these bases (the mainland bases are 2500 miles away),